Meridian Forward AS2 report

Learning Team-10

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Establishing the HR function and workforce readiness for the new business alignment.

Our diagnosis

Meridian expects the Bengaluru centre to own global outcomes, but important decisions remain with other teams. We see a gap between responsibility and workable decision authority. Kabir's delivery commitment makes this visible: he depends on approvals whose timing and escalation route he does not fully control (Meridian Forward, n.d., P008, P012–P014).

We do not treat every delay as an authority problem. P050 describes four projects where approval took longer than engineering and two submissions with incomplete evidence. Our response therefore combines clearer decision rights, better submission quality and a workforce plan based on usable hours.

Business mandate and proposed response

India must support global platforms and more original design while existing services continue. The transition has a restricted budget, and customer consent, pricing and major architecture exceptions require their authorised owners (P009, P011, P044). We propose a bounded pilot with local technical decisions inside agreed limits, a named owner for each reserved decision and a clear escalation route.

Why recruitment alone will not solve the problem

Workforce planning identifies real skill and time gaps. Recruitment can fill those gaps, but a new employee cannot grant customer permission or pricing approval. Equally, clearer authority cannot remove a genuine shortage of specialist capacity. We need both a workable decision process and people who can perform the required work.

Scope of our evidence

Original case claims use P paragraph identifiers. Numerical inputs come from the Session 5 quantitative supplement, Q5.01–Q5.08, for one four-week work package only. Our role allocations, reporting arrangements, response deadlines and recruitment choices are proposals. We do not extrapolate the exercise to all 8,400 employees or validate the 600-position request.

Business alignment and HR arrangements

Our proposed structure

We apply selective decentralization: routine technical decisions sit with the relevant specialists within written limits, while authorised owners retain pricing, consent and major exceptions. Mintzberg's framework helps us match decision power with expertise without removing necessary controls (Mintzberg, 1980). Existing services retain standard procedures; new pilot work uses closer cross-functional coordination.

Role	Responsibility and reporting
Rao	Pilot sponsor. Sets priorities and resolves service trade-offs with retained owners.
Kabir	Coordinates agreed work, checks release evidence and tracks dependencies. Reports pilot issues to Rao.
SHRBP	Links business needs to workforce, job design and fair selection. Proposed link to Rao for priorities and central HR for standards.
Line managers	Approve employee release hours, protect current services and supervise delivery.
HR specialists and shared services	Specialists advise on role requirements and selection. Shared services administer contracts and records.
Architecture and commercial/data reviewers	Set standards or connect authorised owners. Required approvals remain explicit.

Decision process and escalation

Before work starts, Rao and retained owners agree technical thresholds, evidence requirements and the approval sequence. Kabir keeps one log showing the decision, owner, submission date and missing evidence. We propose acknowledgement within one working day and a decision or specific evidence request within two. These deadlines need owner agreement. Kabir escalates overdue items to Rao and the retained owner. Silence never authorises release.

Organizational parts and coordination

For this pilot, Rao performs the strategic-apex role, Kabir the middle-line role and delivery staff the operating core. Architecture standards represent a technostructure function; HR provides support. This is a functional mapping for the pilot, not a complete company organogram. Q5.06 provides four existing governance participants with protected time outside the 60-person pool; we do not count them as new recruits.

Work design and workforce plan

Work changes and role requirements

Create a decision log and a tested exception guide. Redesign handoffs and role authority. Retain existing service commitments. Transfer only manager-approved hours into pilot work. Remove the duplicate customer-pack request only after both requesters accept one authoritative output with a named regional receiving owner. Data staff need reconciliation skills; QA needs testing and risk judgement; documentation support needs expert validation of contract exceptions.

Calculation basis

The supplied working window is 160 contracted hours. A 20% allowance leaves 128 productive hours per employee. We then deduct fixed existing-service hours. The workbook links source inputs, named roster allocations and role gaps through formulas. Headcount is the number of people; deployable capacity is their relevant time after other commitments.

Role	Pilot demand h	Internal assigned h	Gap h	Vendors	Cost INR
Engineering	560	560	0	0	0
Analytics	368	368	0	0	0
Operations	212	212	0	0	0
Data preparation	272	192	80	1	88,000
Quality assurance	264	192	72	1	128,000
Legacy expertise	192	128	64	1	160,000
Total	1868	1652	216	3	376,000

Example: data demand is 60 packs × 4 hours + 32 coordination hours = 272. Six internal employees each have 128 − 96 = 32 pilot hours, giving 192. The gap is 80 hours. One vendor supplies 128 × 80% proficiency = 102.4 effective hours and costs 160 paid hours × INR 550 = INR 88,000.

Deployment and sourcing choice

The 60-person pool offers 1,984 potential pilot hours; our named allocation uses 1,652. The remaining 332 hours belong to other roles and cannot fill these gaps under Q5’s skill restriction. Three role-specific vendors fit the INR 600,000 budget and eight-worker ceiling. Permanent hires take eight weeks and provide no capacity in this window. Develop internal people with protected learning time while retaining internal expertise and authorisation.

Attraction selection and implementation

Credible jobs and fair entry

Sana coordinates internal mobility and qualified vendor suppliers. Role offers must state the real authority, workload, supervision and learning support. Managers confirm service cover before releasing internal employees. Use a common incident brief, a work sample and a structured interview. Assess technical accuracy, risk judgement and evidence use. Two assessors record their reasons before viewing any AI rank, reducing the risk that style or historical proxies drive selection (P061, P075–P076, P090; Dastin, 2018).

Timing	Owner and action	Readiness evidence
Before week 1	Sana, procurement and line managers confirm candidates, scope and release.	Agreed authority, signed hours, selection record and vendor start.
Week 1	Kabir, access owners and role leads arrange supervised onboarding.	Approved access, accepted first output and explanation of escalation.
Weeks 2–3	Role leads protect teaching blocks and review delivery.	Accepted work, actual hours, approval age and service cover.
Week 4	Rao, SHRBP and Finance decide whether to continue or revise.	Quality, spending, unresolved approvals and revised staffing needs.

Costs and knowledge transfer

Vendor cost is INR 376,000 for the four-week window, leaving INR 224,000 of budget headroom. This is not a claimed saving. Q5 includes ordinary HR/procurement advice in the allowance. Internal experts validate contract meaning and teach within protected documentation/teaching blocks. Any additional specialist workload or sourcing charge outside the supplied inputs needs a separate estimate before approval.

A less favourable scenario

If vendor proficiency falls from 80% to 60%, effective capacity becomes 76.8 hours each. Data then needs two vendors, while QA and legacy expertise need one each. Total cost rises to INR 464,000. This remains within budget if the extra worker can start on time. If the proposed workflow and single output do not gain approval, current coordination and duplication require six vendors costing INR 640,000. We would reduce or defer scope and re-cost rather than assume extra funds.

Assumptions verification and continuity

Assumption or condition	Verification	Response if it fails
Lower coordination hours	Owners agree thresholds, sequence and response clock.	Use current-workflow hours and re-cost.
One accepted customer pack	Both requesters approve the same output and receiver.	Retain duplicate workload.
Internal staff release	Service managers approve named hours without cutting fixed duties.	Recalculate gaps or reduce scope.
Vendor readiness	Procurement verifies start, capability and access.	Test slower learning or defer affected work.
Protected expert guidance	Manager books internal teaching time.	Do not treat vendors as independent internal expertise.

What we will monitor and learn

We will track approval age separately from evidence rework, along with accepted outputs, actual role hours, service continuity and spend. Pause affected work if consent, access or service cover is missing. Keep a dated record of what the team proposed, what faculty challenged, what changed and what was learned. AS3 and AS4 can use actual evidence to revise development, performance expectations and retention decisions. The HR function coordinates this lifecycle so entry promises, learning and performance match the same business mandate.

References

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